

Digital Leisure | MP3 Player Test

sounds good on the bundled earbuds and extremely good on the reference earplugs. Good bass (though not nano-class bass), and very good vocal reproduction. Treble was sharp but not too rich—just right!

All the players in this category are very good performers. Although differences in performance are clearly noticeable to trained ears, any of these players would suit you if music quality is the only qualification. There's no clear all-round winner here, and every one of these players left some sort of an impression on us.

Freedom Of Choice

One of our biggest fears has always been making decisions, particularly in the absence of hindsight. So you've 10,000 odd bucks to burn; you want something compact, smart, and most of all, your ears crave audiophile-grade sound on the move. You might want to check out our Digit Best Buy Silver winner, the Apple iPod nano 2GB, priced at Rs 9,800. It is a sound decision (pun intended) to make.

BEST BUY
digit
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Apple iPod Nano
Aural excellence par none

A little cheaper, a lot of features richer, and a little lower on the audiophile scale is the Sandisk Sansa e250—2 GB of functional fun, all for Rs 8,150. Digit Best Buy Gold belongs here.

For something really funky and thoroughly unconventional, go the Sony NW-S203F way—the sound is good, and it actually looks good tucked into a sweaty armband. A lifetime workout partner at a bargain price of Rs 7,990.

You prefer your chauffeur to do the driving; you've been there, done that, you also like to dabble in a little music between board rooms, but as always, quality and impressions count. Samsung YP-K3 all the way—a gorgeous looking, great sounding PMP. At Rs 9,000, even good old Giorgio would approve of an YP-K3 peeking out of that Armani's pocket.

WE WILL ROCK YOU... Rs 10,001 and above

This is the category for the rich or for the enthusiast. We doubt many in India will bite, coughing up more than 10,000 for a few odd MP3s and videos. However, there is a niche audience—"gadgetophiles," if you will—who have enough to burn on costly PMPs.

When Size Matters...

Hard drive based players have nearly died off, with manufacturers relying more and more on Flash. Why not? It's infinitely more dependable, cheaper to manufacture, and how much storage do you need anyway?

If you're one of those who like to lug their entire music collection with them, or carry a bunch of movies on your player, then measly 6 or 8 GB players aren't going to cut it.

Our search revealed three portable media players based on hard drives—a 1-inch microdrive-based player from MobiBlu, the DHH-200, an 80 GB fifth-generation iPod video, and Cowon's A2 30GB. While the MobiBlu was the minnow, it looks good, decent with light and dark blue tones. The screen is an 18-bit affair, though not as good as the screens on the other two. The Apple 80GB looks every bit the part, but it leans towards music rather than movies with a screen that is just 2.5 inches diagonally. Make no mistake however; this 65K colour screen is much better than the one of the DHH-200, and far more suited to movies.

The Cowon is perhaps the best looker, despite its colossal size. The player has an off-white colour tone, with a band of dark steel grey running around all the sides. A neat, flush fitting cover hides the USB port and the video connectivity (AV out). The screen—a massive four inches—is clear, crisp, and vivid. Watching movies on the Cowon is fun, simply because of the wide aspect ratio and screen size.

Apple's 80GB iPod has very similar features to the nano series, except for as mentioned a larger screen and video playback support. It's a good bit bulkier too, and heavier. Sound quality is top notch on the iPod video; in fact, this player seems to drive the reference earphones better than do the nanos. Its bundled earplugs are also better in terms of sound quality, though if you settle for this player, do try to get another set of cans for more bang.



MobiBlu DH-200

The Cowon A2 is a capable multimedia companion and handles all the MP3s you can throw at it without breaking a sweat.

Sound is good, but not as good as the iPod video, mainly lacking deep bass. The bass you do get is clean and low, but lacks thump. Mids are good (something we've noticed Cowon's good at), while treble is easily on par with the iPod video. In comparison, however, we were disappointed that the Flash-based D2 sounds better. MobiBlu was somewhat of an unknown entity, and pitting it against the giants seemed utterly ruthless. However, this is a decent media player, with good music capabilities even with the default headphones.



Cowon A2



Apple iPod Video 80GB

If you want a large screen to watch all your movies, you'll have to make do with 50 GB less space than the iPod video, though in return you get a marvellous screen. This one is less suitable for a music enthusiast simply because of its sheer bulk, and the fact that the iPod sounds better across all genres.